



SHARIF'S SUPPORTERS POURED OUT FOR THE LONG MARCH IN LAHORE (LEFT); GENERAL KAYANI KEPT A STRATEGIC DISTANCE

League (Nawaz)—PML-N—performed better than he could have imagined. Riding a wave of anti-incumbent feeling against Musharraf and his King's Party, even previously unknown candidates won, giving Sharif the largest number of seats in Punjab—his home base—and a substantial number in the federal Parliament. For once he was also on the right side of liberal civil society, having decided to champion the cause of the judiciary sacked by Musharraf, even though—given his record of attacking the Supreme Court while in power—his critics saw in it cynical opportunism to oppose the man who had deposed him.

But Sharif was also a changed man. He may have suddenly got a fuller head of hair than when he left for Saudi Arabia, but he also seemed to exude more humility and his public statements were never less than measured, a remarkable transformation for a man often known for shooting from the hip. Shrewdly, he correctly judged the public mood, which was disgusted with Musharraf's attempts to perpetuate his rule and the abandonment of any kind of principled politics, but also fearful of a return to the internecine feuding between civilian politicians that characterised the '90s. His joining hands with erstwhile rival Zardari to form governments in Islamabad and in Punjab was widely lauded as the beginning of a new chapter in Pakistan's politics. But